

## REUSABLE DIRECTIVE

# Optimal Task Brief

*A practical template for giving Codex the context, authority, constraints, and finish line needed to deliver excellent work.*

**THE RULE** Fill the Essentials every time. Add only the optional modules that materially change the work. Delete guidance text before sending if you want a cleaner brief.

## How to use this template

- Start with the outcome: describe the finished result, not just the activity.
- Supply the context and source material that would change a good decision.
- State boundaries, permissions, and irreversible actions explicitly.
- Define how the result will be checked and what “done” means.
- For quick tasks, send only the one-minute brief below; omit the rest.

## One-minute brief

|             |                                                       |
|-------------|-------------------------------------------------------|
| Outcome     | [What should exist or be true when finished?]         |
| Context     | [Why this matters; audience; current state.]          |
| Inputs      | [Files, links, examples, data, or prior work to use.] |
| Constraints | [Must / must not; deadline; format; scope; risk.]     |
| Done when   | [Tests, review criteria, and expected handoff.]       |

## 1. Essentials

Complete this section for every task. Be concrete; short answers are enough.

**Task name** [Short, recognizable label]

[Type here]

**Desired outcome** [Describe the final state or artifact.] *Example: “A tested Python CLI that converts Suite2p outputs into tidy CSV files.”*

[Type here]

**Why this matters** [Decision, workflow, user need, or problem this supports.]

[Type here]

**Audience / user** [Who will read, run, approve, or maintain the result?]

[Type here]

**Current state** [What exists now? What has already been tried?]

[Type here]

**Inputs and sources** [List or attach files, folders, links, examples, datasets, and source-of-truth material.]

[Type here]

**SOURCE PRIORITY** If sources conflict, identify the authority order. Example: “The attached protocol overrides README text; existing tests override comments.”

**Deliverable(s)** [Exact artifact, answer, change, or action expected; include format and location.]

[Type here]

**Out of scope** [What should remain untouched or explicitly not be solved?]

[Type here]

## 2. Execution contract

Use this section to set autonomy, risk, quality, and communication expectations.

**Success criteria** [Observable checks that distinguish complete from merely attempted.]

[Type here]

**Constraints and invariants** [Must keep; must avoid; compatibility; style; performance; compliance; budget.]

[Type here]

**Authority and permissions** [Actions allowed without asking; actions requiring approval.]

[Type here]

**GOOD DEFAULT** Allow read-only inspection and reversible in-scope edits. Require confirmation for destructive actions, external messages, purchases, publication, credential use, or scope expansion.

**Decision policy** [When details are missing, should Codex infer, present options, or pause?]

[Type here]

**Verification** [Tests, renders, calculations, cross-checks, reviewers, or acceptance procedure.]

[Type here]

**Communication** [Update frequency, desired explanation depth, and when to escalate blockers.]

[Type here]

**Final handoff** [What the closing response must contain: links, summary, risks, commands, next steps.]

[Type here]

### 3. Optional task modules

Copy the relevant prompts into your brief. Skip modules that do not affect the result.

| Use when                       | Add these details                                                                                                                                            |
|--------------------------------|--------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|
| <b>Code / debugging</b>        | Repository and branch; runtime; target behavior; reproduction steps; logs; compatibility; files not to touch; tests and performance limits.                  |
| <b>Research / analysis</b>     | Decision to support; date range; geography; acceptable sources; freshness; evidence standard; citation format; assumptions; comparison criteria.             |
| <b>Documents / slides</b>      | Audience; purpose; source material; length; brand or visual reference; structure; tone; editable output format; render and layout requirements.              |
| <b>Data / spreadsheets</b>     | Input schema; units; missing-value rules; transformations; formulas versus values; validation totals; charts; output schema; privacy constraints.            |
| <b>Images / design</b>         | Use context; dimensions; style references; composition; required and forbidden elements; text accuracy; brand colors; file format; variants.                 |
| <b>Browser / UI work</b>       | Target URL or local app; account/session assumptions; exact user flow; browsers/viewports; permitted submissions; screenshot and evidence needs.             |
| <b>Automation / monitoring</b> | Trigger; cadence; timezone; inputs; action; notification target; deduplication; failure handling; stop condition; archive policy.                            |
| <b>External systems</b>        | Named service; account/workspace; records in scope; read versus write authority; recipients; draft versus send; audit trail; rollback plan.                  |
| <b>High-risk domain</b>        | Relevant jurisdiction or policy; professional-review requirement; prohibited actions; uncertainty threshold; authoritative sources; explicit approval gates. |

### Useful preference switches

- Optimize for: [speed / correctness / maintainability / visual polish / cost / minimal change].
- Response style: [concise / explanatory / expert-level / tutorial].
- Tradeoffs: [choose the best default / show 2–3 options / preserve current approach].
- Progress: [work silently / send milestone updates / report each meaningful decision].
- Uncertainty: [state assumptions and continue / verify first / stop when confidence is below \_\_\_\_].

## 4. Paste-ready master prompt

Replace bracketed text and remove unused lines. This is the shortest complete version of the template.

### **TASK**

*[Name the task and describe the finished outcome.]*

### **CONTEXT**

*[Explain why it matters, who it serves, the current state, and relevant history.]*

### **INPUTS**

*[Attach or list files, links, examples, data, and sources. State source priority if they conflict.]*

### **DELIVERABLES**

*[Specify artifacts or actions, formats, locations, and expected final handoff.]*

### **SCOPE AND CONSTRAINTS**

*[State what is in scope, out of scope, must remain unchanged, and any deadline, compatibility, style, cost, privacy, or policy limits.]*

### **AUTHORITY**

*[State what you may do without asking and what requires approval.]*

### **WORKING POLICY**

*[State whether to infer reasonable details, offer options, or pause. Tell me how often to update you.]*

### **QUALITY BAR AND VERIFICATION**

*[Define success criteria, required tests or checks, and what “done” means.]*

### **OPTIONAL TASK-SPECIFIC DETAILS**

*[Add only the relevant module details from page 4.]*

Please inspect the available context first, make reasonable in-scope assumptions explicit, complete and verify the work, and finish with a concise handoff covering the outcome, changed artifacts, verification performed, remaining risks, and the most useful next step.

## Pre-send check

- The finished outcome is concrete and observable.
- All necessary inputs are attached or locatable.
- Scope, protected areas, and approval gates are explicit.
- The quality bar and verification method are stated.
- Optional detail is included only where it changes execution.